religious and political parties from the twin districts (except for the BJP) have now come together, pledging to fight for their constitutional rights.

Educationist and innovator Sonam Wangchuk, among the vanguard in the February 3 march, blames the BJP-led Centre for failing to fulfil its promises to Ladakh. The Magsaysay award winner had initially been an avid supporter of UT status, but now says, "The present situation, where everything is decided by the lieutenant governor, cannot continue. We were forced into calling the protest as there has been no response to the demands of the Ladakh Apex Body from the Union home ministry. Meanwhile, local BJP leaders were spreading rumours that we had little support. We wanted to show that everyone in Ladakh supports us."

In Ladakh's earlier avatar, Kargil and Leh used to send two elected legislators to the Jammu and Kashmir assembly (and two nominated members to the legislative council). After J&K was bifurcated into UTs, Ladakh now lacks legislative representation. Wangchuk has announced a fast unto death if the central government does not meet their demands at the next meeting in Delhi on February 19. The Ladakh Apex Body, presently led by former BJP MP and president of the Ladakh Buddhist Association Thupstan Chewang, will attend the meeting with members of the high-powered committee (HPC) for Ladakh led by Union MoS for home, Nityanand Rai.

Wangchuk says discussing environmental degradation is also a top priority. "Our ecosystem is fragile. The glaciers are retreating near the highways and there will be havoc if industries are allowed to set up operations here. It will completely dry our water resources," says the activist on whose life Aamir Khan's character in *3 Idiots* was based. "We want Sixth Schedule protection to safeguard our identity and environment. There are industries, hotels and MNCs waiting at the door to start businesses in Ladakh. Earlier, the industrial policy announced by the L-G was withdrawn after we opposed it. This is why the schedule is vital to protect our region."



A CRUCIAL DEMAND IS FOR THE SIXTH SCHEDULE, WHICH ENTITLES TRIBAL AREAS TO SET UP AUTONOMOUS ADMINISTRATIVE DISTRICT COUNCILS

Ladakh's population is 97 per cent tribal (comprising the Balti, Beda, Bot, Boto, Brokpa, Drokpa, Dard, Shin, Changpa, Garra, Mon and Purigpa tribes) and is thus a valid claimant for Sixth Schedule coverage and its levers of self-governance. The constitutional provision entitles a region with 50 per cent or more tribals to set up autonomous district councils with legislative and administrative autonomy. For Ladakh, it would offer protective layers for its distinct culture and ecology, agrarian rights, including rights on land, transfer of funds for speedy development and other such matters. The National Commission for Scheduled Tribes led by Dr Nand Kumar Sai had recommended the Sixth Schedule for Ladakh back in September 2019. Currently, 10 such autonomous councils exist in the tribal areas of Meghalaya, Assam, Mizoram and Tripura.

The issue is going to be a major factor in the Lok Sabha election and could upset the BJP's prospects if it does not pay heed. The Opposition alliance is also contemplating a joint candidate against the saffron party, which currently holds the Ladakh Lok Sabha seat. "The implications are not just for the elections here...this could resonate in the rest of India—of how the ruling party has backtracked on its promises," says Wangchuk, pointing to the 2019 BJP poll manifesto, which had promised that the region would be covered by the Sixth Schedule.

Political activist Sajjad Kargili, who had participated in the previous meeting with the HPC, notes that the response from the government has been cold so far. He is worried by the rising unemployment rate in the region, and points to the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) of the Union ministry of statistics & programme implementation, which says over 26 per cent of the graduates in Ladakh are unemployed. "Yet the government has done nothing. The youth are frustrated due to lack of jobs. Our demands are well within our constitutional rights. They have not set up a public service commission or provided job reservation," he says.

The local BJP leaders agree that they are facing issues on the ground but are optimistic that Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government will act to safeguard the region. BJP state president Phunchok Stanzin says, "The government has made the Ladakh Resident Certificate compulsory for jobs. Likewise, the Centre will safeguard our identity and environment through some provision, whether it is the Sixth Schedule or Article 371," he says. "We are hoping that something will be done before the Lok Sabha election." It seems the Ladakhis are also pinning their hopes on this, that the general election will force the Centre's hand and get them some concessions. ■